

Imagine grabbing a long lunch with a couple of old friends. As you walk back to your car, you notice something stuck to the windshield: a \$68 parking ticket.

How would you react?

This happened to me a few weeks after I moved to Los Angeles. When I saw the ticket, I stopped and realized this was a special moment: “My first parking ticket—now I *really* live in LA.”

Years before that, however, something like this would have ruined my entire day. “What? It wasn’t even five minutes past the deadline! How could they do this? Ugh. This isn’t fair.” This reaction is filled with what I call “hot” emotions, like anger, disbelief, and guilt. But as I’ve worked on my money confidence, I’ve learned to transform those reactions into a sense of calm and cool. Now, I might say, “It happened, it was my fault, and I can pay for it.” That’s it! No drama, no anger, just taking these minor money situations in stride.

I call this taking it “from hot to cool.” It’s a powerful mindset you can apply to all the difficult areas of your life—especially money.

Here’s another example. Imagine you go out to dinner with friends. Someone orders extra appetizers and a \$100 bottle of wine that you didn’t even drink—yet everyone plans to split the bill.

- » **Hot:** You freak out. “Oh my god, I’m never doing this again.” You think about it all night, resent your friends, and vent about it the next day on Reddit, which I gleefully read on /r/AmITheAsshole while sipping my morning coffee.
- » **Cool:** You shrug and feel grateful for a fun night out. Perhaps you’ve already created an “Unexpected Expense” fund and you can afford to be generous. Or you speak up and ask for a separate check—no big deal. It’s up to you. But you remain completely calm and confident.

Cool confidence means you can handle any financial situation that life throws at you. So how do you get to that level? It’s not through affirmations or power poses. As you know, I don’t buy motivational posters that say “You are enough” or “Just Breathe” to hang in my kitchen.